

PTM Preparation Guide — Elementary Program

A comprehensive reference for elementary teachers to prepare for Parent-Teacher Meetings. This guide covers the school's position on common parent questions and how to respond effectively.

Section 1: Academic Learning at Home

1.1 Internet & AI Tools

Parent question: *Can my child use internet resources and AI tools for their research work and assignments at home?*

School position: Students must refrain from using internet resources and AI tools for their work. The elementary program is not the time to introduce these tools.

Why:

- We want students to read books and summarize in their own words
- AI tools hand out direct answers, bypassing the mental work of summarization
- The costs outweigh the benefits at this age
- We have well-stocked classroom libraries and can provide additional reading material

What to tell parents:

- Kindly redirect your child to use offline materials
- As a program, we will not direct your child to do internet research
- We have experimented with this in the past, and it's very clear that costs exceed benefits for children of this age
- There will be a time and place for these tools, introduced in a controlled way, but not now

1.2 Homework Philosophy

Parent question: *How much homework does my child get? Should they be doing more work at home?*

School position: We do not assign explicit homework. Work is designed to be completed during school hours.

Key points:

- We set deadlines for work, but don't mandate it be done at home
- There is sufficient time in school for well-organized students to complete their work
- Occasionally, if a child hasn't prioritized, they may need to take work home to meet deadlines — that's okay
- During particularly busy weeks (1-2 per year), some work may go home

- At home, students should read, pursue interests, and use MindSpark if they choose

What to tell parents:

- We don't assign homework; we set completion deadlines
 - If your child is bringing work home regularly, it may be a prioritization issue — we can discuss
 - Home time is for reading, hobbies, play, and pursuing interests
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1.3 How to Support Learning at Home

Parent question: *What should evenings and weekends look like? Should I be teaching my child anything? My child says "nothing happened at school" — how do I engage?*

School position: Unless we explicitly ask you, do not teach your child at home. Let them live out their childhood.

What children should do at home:

- Go outside and play
- Pursue sports, hobby classes, and interests
- Hang out with friends
- Read for pleasure
- Play family games — card games, strategy games, language and math games

What parents should do:

- Share your own love of reading, writing, and learning
- Share your hobbies, your work day, your life
- Take them to live shows, concerts, cultural events
- Introduce them to your culture through travel and experience
- Let them see the best of human accomplishment
- Foster a culture of curiosity, learning, reading, and discussion

What parents should NOT do:

- Teach subjects at home (unless school explicitly asks)
- Assign drills, workbooks, or extra practice
- Pressure the child to share about their school day — share yours first and be patient
- Waste time teaching when they could be experiencing

When we will ask for help:

- In rare cases, we may tell specific families that supplementation is needed
 - Wait for our guidance before adding academic work at home
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Section 2: Reading & Writing Development

2.1 Vocabulary & Independent Reading

Parent question: *My child doesn't enjoy reading independently because they don't understand the meaning of many words. Their reading fluency is good, but they keep asking the meaning of words. How can they become an independent reader?*

School position: The challenge here is vocabulary, not fluency. This is a long journey that takes time.

Understanding the problem:

- The child can decode (say the word aloud) but doesn't understand the meaning
- If more than 10% of words in a book are unknown, reading becomes painful and unpleasant
- This is not a fluency issue — it's a vocabulary issue

How to help:

- Give them books where words may be hard to decode but meanings are simple
 - This is the path to independent reading — matching books to vocabulary level, not reading level
 - Adults should use rich vocabulary at home naturally
 - Audiobooks help, especially if parents don't have rich vocabulary themselves — the child hears rich language
 - Building vocabulary is a long journey; be patient
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2.2 Spelling Errors in Writing

Parent question: *My child can recall the correct spelling verbally, but makes errors when writing. Even when pointed out, they don't always correct it.*

School position: We encourage parents to step back rather than intervene on spelling.

Two types of spelling issues:

1. **They don't know the correct spelling** — a knowledge gap
2. **They know the spelling but execute it wrong** — a transcription issue

In this case (execution errors):

- The child knows the spelling but makes errors while writing
- This is addressed in school through editing checklists and peer spelling checks
- These school mechanisms, combined with our spelling development work, are sufficient

Important guidance for parents:

- When a child has put effort into writing, the first feedback should NOT be about spelling errors
 - Focus first on substance — the content, the ideas, what they're trying to share
 - Consider carefully whether you even want to offer spelling feedback
 - If we need additional help from parents, we will come and ask
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2.3 Creative Writing

Parent question: *What strategies can help my child develop creative writing skills?*

School position: Creative writing development is within the ambit of school work.

What the school does:

- Runs a rich creative expression program
- Children write across various genres
- They practice writing in various forms

What parents should do:

- Share your love for writing — poems, short stories, diary entries
 - Model writing as a joyful activity
 - Do not sit them down and teach them to write creatively — allow the school to handle that
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2.4 Writing Resistance

Parent question: *My child shows resistance towards writing at home. How can I help?*

School position: This is not the parents' role to solve. Writing resistance cannot be resolved by making students do more writing — that is counterproductive.

What parents should do:

- Motivate by example — show that you write a lot yourself
- Make shopping lists, keep a diary, write things you're interested in
- Valorize writing — show that you value it
- The more parents demonstrate they value writing, the more easily children adopt it

What parents should NOT do:

- Force more writing practice
 - Treat writing as a chore or assignment
 - Pressure the child to write
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Section 3: School Programs & Assessment

3.1 Personalized Learning Groups (formerly internal: BUDS Program)

Parent question: *My child is part of a special group. How has this helped? Will it continue?*

Note to teachers: Do not use the internal program name with parents. Refer to it as "personalized learning support" or "small group instruction."

What this program is:

- Designed for students who have shown they have slightly different needs
- For part of the day, students get one-on-one or very small group instruction

- Often these children need more support with executive function (planning, choosing work, self-direction)
- The learning area is kept quieter, with less movement and fewer distractions

What it provides:

1. **Removed executive function requirement** — students don't need to plan their own work; they're given a structured set of carefully designed workbooks across English, Math, and Science
2. **Reduced distractions** — a calmer environment that supports focus
3. **Personalized pacing** — right work at the right time with right level of support

Important messaging:

- It is NOT a separate school or a caste system
- Students remain part of the overall community
- It's only for some parts of the day
- Different children experience it differently
- The school fully intends to continue this program
- The fundamental idea is personalizing education for all children

Compared to conventional schooling:

- Conventional schooling would give structure but NOT personalized one-on-one support
- This setup gives both: structure AND individualized instruction
- That combination is what we believe is ideal for these children's development

3.2 Group Placement

Parent question: *My child has heard about a different group doing different work. Why aren't they in that group? Can we get them in?*

School position: Group placement is within the teacher's professional remit.

Key points:

- We constantly observe and assess children
- Placement is based on present ability and interest
- We aim for the greatest chance of immediate success and progress
- As we work with children, we know when they can be switched to another group
- We request parents to stay out of this process

If a child asks:

- We deal with children directly about this
- Any child who is keen to observe another group's lesson is always welcome
- We operate an open lesson policy — any child who wants to attend can

3.3 Benchmarking Exams

Parent question: *I heard my child recently wrote some exams. What are these for? Can I see results?*

School position: This was a benchmarking exercise, not school exams. Individual results are not shared per school policy.

What it is:

- Conducted by Educational Initiatives, a national benchmarking organization
- Taken by students above Grade 3 across English, Math, and Science
- 50,000 to 1 lakh students take this across the country
- No preparation required — students just come and sit

Purpose:

- Helps the school understand strengths and weaknesses of the overall program
- Allows the school to make data-driven improvements
- NOT for evaluating individual children (we already understand them)

Results sharing:

- As a school, we perform very well — upper quartile nationally, some classrooms in top 5-10%
- School policy: we do not share individual student numbers
- If a parent insists, ask them to take it up with admin/founders
- **Proactive:** If a specific child has scored significantly below expectations (below 50th percentile), teachers should proactively mention that there are some deficiencies in specific areas, framing it as "we always knew this and have now verified it"

Going forward:

- Will be conducted 1-2 times per year as a regular school process

3.4 Olympiad Results

Parent question: *My child's Olympiad results don't seem to match what you've told me about their performance. Can you explain?*

School position: Olympiads are NOT a valid benchmark of your child's learning. We do not endorse them.

Why Olympiad results are misleading:

- Content is tailored to the NEXT grade's curriculum, not the current one
- **Science:** Extremely memory-based — not the science we believe in
- **English:** A poor paper that doesn't test real comprehension
- **Math:** Purely procedural — not conceptual
- Started as a student request years ago; the school does not endorse them

What we did instead:

- Conducted Educational Initiatives benchmarking, which has come completely in line with our own observations of children
- This is the valid measure, not Olympiads

What to tell parents:

- If your child is motivated to prepare and take Olympiads on their own initiative, that's fine
 - Do NOT treat results as a benchmark or guideline for learning
 - Our own reporting and the EI benchmarking are the valid measures
 - Olympiads give exposure to competitive setups, but results don't mean much
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3.5 Elementary to Adolescent Transition

Parent question: *As my child moves from elementary to the adolescent program, is there specific work they should do?*

School position: MindSpark and reading are the best preparation.

- Continue MindSpark practice (1 hour math/week, 1 hour language/week)
 - If the child wants to do more, let them
 - Reading books of their interest is the single best thing — children who read a lot over summer come back significantly improved
 - For math: MindSpark
 - For English: MindSpark for grammar/vocab, but no substitute for reading for pleasure
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Section 4: Screen Time & Summer

4.1 Screen Time Guidance

Parent question: *How much screen time is appropriate? What's the school's view?*

School position: Different screens have different merits and demerits. It's about the type of screen time, not just the amount.

Smartphones — NEVER:

- Allows constant task-switching between apps
- Absolutely inappropriate for any age child
- Never hand over a smartphone to a child

Tablets for consumption — NO:

- Same concerns as smartphones for elementary children
- Not recommended as a tool for passive consumption

Big screen (TV/projector) as family activity — FINE:

- Family watching a movie together once a week is great
- Nature shows, documentaries, age-appropriate movies

- The key: the whole family watches and processes it together
- This has genuine value

Computers/laptops as tools — SOME VALUE with supervision:

- Using computers for specific skills (Canva, coding projects) with one-on-one supervision is okay
- The open internet is almost never valuable — promotes passive consumption
- No access to open internet without direct adult supervision
- In the adolescent program, school teaches specific computer skills via electives without general internet access

MindSpark — OKAY:

- A whitelisted, personalized learning tool — not passive consumption
- In school, computers only have access to MindSpark, not the general internet
- Fine to use at home for practice

Core message: Have judgment about what is good vs bad screen time. It's not about total minutes — it's about what kind.

4.2 Summer Activities at Home

Parent question: *What can be done at home during summer holidays to keep my child engaged and in touch with learning?*

School position: MindSpark + reading for pleasure.

MindSpark:

- Personalized adaptive learning software, tailored to each child's level
- Recommended: 1 hour of math per week and 1 hour of language per week
- Must be done every week — not piled up at the end of summer
- Some children may need more time; school will communicate this individually
- Preferred over books because no book can match this level of personalization

Reading:

- Students who spend summer reading for pleasure come back significantly improved
- This is the single best thing a child can do over summer
- Encourage reading books of their interest

4.3 Summer Program

Parent question: *Why is there no summer program this year?*

School position: There IS a summer program — it's just structured differently this year.

What's changed:

- Previously: open the entire summer

- This year: consolidated schedule
- Younger students: full month of May
- Older students: part of May

Why the change:

- Low attendance was observed over the years
- Consolidating students into one segment allows better instruction
- Allows teachers to take coordinated breaks and come back refreshed
- Creates time for teacher training, which was hard to fit in the old format

Key message: The summer program is very much continuing — it just looks slightly different this year.

Section 5: Social, Behavioral & Well-being

5.1 Social Conflicts & Friendships

Parent question: *My child is having social problems at school — conflicts with peers, exclusion, etc.*

Why conflicts are more visible in our classrooms:

- In Montessori, students talk and engage freely
- In traditional schools, conflicts are suppressed because students aren't allowed to interact
- More visible conflicts are a natural byproduct of learning to collaborate
- We must accept that social conflicts will happen

Three levels of social conflict:

Type	Severity	School Response
Physical misconduct (pushing, hitting)	Unacceptable	Immediately stopped and parents informed
Name-calling / inappropriate language	Serious	Students coached; some tolerance as they learn, but firm action if repeated; parents informed
Quiet exclusion (implicit, not overt)	Most challenging	Ongoing work on grace and courtesy; cannot force friendships but insist on inclusion

About quiet exclusion:

- More common in upper elementary (overt bullying is caught quickly)
- Not done explicitly — done implicitly
- Takes sustained engagement with students
- We cannot tell someone to be someone's friend, but we can insist on courtesy and inclusion
- This is hard to resolve and relates to personality types

What to tell parents:

- If it has reached physical or name-calling levels, we would have already acted
- The quieter forms of exclusion are harder but we actively work on them
- This is part of learning to be in community

5.2 Behavior & Discipline

Parent question: *How does the school handle misbehavior? What consequences exist?*

School philosophy: Restorative justice.

Approach:

- We want students to reflect on their misbehavior and its impact on others
- Restoration is done primarily through conversation
- We are NOT focused on preventing incidents — we are focused on helping students learn from them
- Opportunities for reflection are part of the elementary program
- Stories and other tools are used to depersonalize situations and allow independent reflection

Escalation path:

1. **Reflection & conversation** — student reflects on what they did and what they could do differently
2. **Parent involvement** — when behavior crosses limits, parents are brought in for coaching and counseling
3. **Reduced school time** — for severe cases, often related to inability to control impulses, reducing time in school may be necessary; decided case by case, in the interest of both the child and other students

5.3 "My Child Seems Behind"

Parent question: *My child's friend is doing multiplication but mine is still on addition. Should I be worried? Other schools seem further ahead in the syllabus.*

Within the school — child vs child:

- There is a natural window of development
- It's common for some children to be ahead and others to be behind on specific subjects
- As long as it's within the acceptable window, there is nothing to worry about
- Teachers apply professional judgment on the right pacing for each child
- **If we think your child is falling behind the natural window, we will tell you**
- If we are not communicating a concern, everything is fine

Across schools — school vs school:

- Each school is different, but all converge by 9th and 10th grade
- Different schools sequence content differently — this is not a meaningful comparison
- Traditional schools emphasize knowledge memorization; we emphasize understanding and experiencing
- It is not an apples-to-apples comparison

- The Montessori elementary curriculum is very broad and deep
- Minor gaps compared to traditional schools are intentional and not critical

What to tell parents:

- Focus on what skills your child is acquiring, not what specific content another school is covering
 - If we worry about your child falling behind grade-level expectations, we will tell you proactively
 - For all children: reading a lot for pleasure is the best accelerator
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5.4 Hindi/Kannada Without Home Exposure

Parent question: *How can I help my child progress in Hindi or Kannada when we don't have any exposure to these languages at home?*

School position: Keep expectations low and be patient.

Reality:

- Language develops through immersion — that's how your child learned English
- School offers Hindi/Kannada about 2 days per week — not immersive, not daily
- For Kannada especially, there is little exposure in the broader community
- Progress will be slow — make your peace with it

Options:

- If you're worried, you could send them to daily tuitions, but we don't endorse or require it
 - The school will continue its instruction, but without home/community immersion, expectations should be realistic
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5.5 Eating Habits & Water

Parent question: *My child doesn't finish their lunch. They don't drink enough water.*

School position: This is part of the culture of independence we want to develop.

- We eat as a community but don't individually coax children
 - Finishing lunch and drinking water is the child's responsibility
 - Parents should set up their own mechanisms with their child
 - When teachers notice, they talk to children, but this is not a teacher's goal
 - Same applies to water bottles
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5.6 Responsible at School, Not at Home

Parent question: *My child is very responsible at school and completes tasks, but at home they don't take care of things.*

School position: This is outside the scope of our PTM conversation.

- There is a lot of literature available on this

- Suggest parents read online or ask Delphi
- During PTM, we want to focus on what we've observed at school
- Parents can attend observation conversations where these topics are discussed as a community

Quick Reference: Key Themes Across All Topics

Theme	Message
Parent role	Model behavior, don't teach. Share your life, interests, and love of learning.
School role	We handle instruction. If we need your help, we will ask explicitly.
Comparison	Don't compare your child to others or to other schools.
No news = good news	If we're not raising a concern, your child is within acceptable range.
Reading	The single most impactful thing a child can do at home.
Writing	Focus on content, not mechanics. Model it, don't force it.
Screens	Type matters more than amount. No phones/tablets. Family viewing is fine.
Independence	We're building independence. Step back and let the child develop.
Discipline	Restorative, not punitive. Reflection over punishment.
Communication	We will tell you if something needs attention. Trust the process.